

Species Profile: Gorilla ■

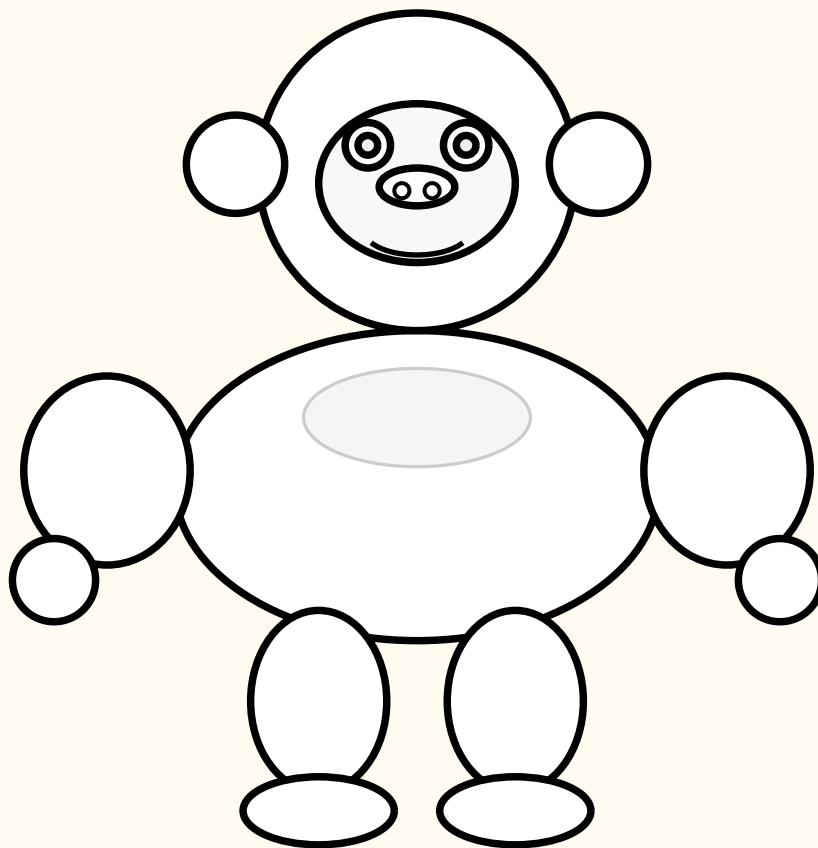
Scientific Name:	Gorilla beringei / Gorilla gorilla
IUCN Red List Status:	Critically Endangered
Range Countries:	DR Congo, Uganda, Rwanda, Cameroon, Gabon
Primary Habitat:	Tropical rainforests and mountain forests of Central Africa
Diet:	Herbivore — leaves, stems, fruit, bark, and roots
Mass:	135–220 kg (male), 70–90 kg (female)
Wild Population:	Fewer than 1,100 mountain gorillas remain
Lifespan:	35–40 years in the wild

Advanced Biology & Behaviour ■

- There are two species: Eastern gorilla (*G. beringei*) and Western gorilla (*G. gorilla*), each with two subspecies.
- Gorillas are a 'keystone species' — they disperse seeds across vast areas, shaping the forest.
- Mountain gorilla numbers have actually INCREASED slightly due to intensive conservation — a rare success story.
- Gorillas are susceptible to every human respiratory illness, making researcher contact protocols critical.
- The Virunga Massif population lives across three countries (DRC, Uganda, Rwanda) requiring cross-border conservation.
- An adult male's home range can span 10–40 km², with ranges overlapping between troops.

Color Me! — Gorilla

Try to use realistic wildlife colours.



Research: Use a wildlife photo for accurate colouring reference.

Activity Worksheets

Word Search — find all 8 terms (horizontal, vertical & diagonal):

C	B	U	N	Z	H	R	V	M	X	G	Z	S	F
C	N	S	E	B	Y	W	G	L	E	O	P	E	W
R	Y	F	I	N	Y	U	R	E	Y	R	P	Z	G
B	B	K	W	L	D	X	T	G	Z	I	U	R	X
D	S	T	E	G	V	A	O	D	G	L	N	I	A
J	G	L	R	K	T	E	N	V	Q	L	S	B	Q
P	A	F	R	I	C	A	R	G	F	A	Z	M	Q
Q	W	H	B	T	L	G	Z	B	E	R	Y	K	C
L	P	A	Y	E	X	V	W	D	A	R	B	Q	M
Y	H	H	I	R	B	L	P	T	O	C	E	L	J
F	A	K	L	P	R	I	M	A	T	E	K	D	M
M	I	C	O	N	S	E	R	V	A	T	I	O	N
Z	T	F	O	R	A	I	N	F	O	R	E	S	T
E	H	X	W	V	C	R	Y	Z	S	Y	N	Z	X

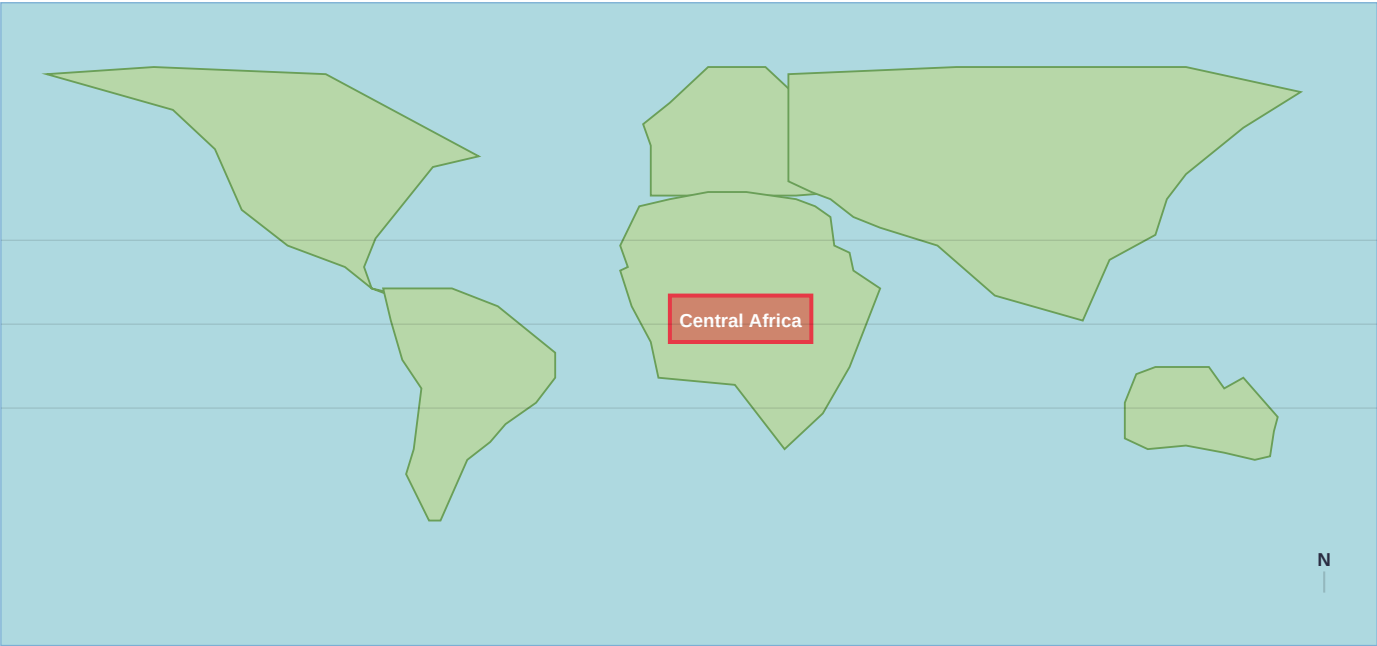
GORILLA	SILVERBACK	RAINFOREST	ENDANGERED
AFRICA	PRIMATE	HABITAT	CONSERVATION

Fill in the Blanks (use the fact file for clues):

- Gorillas live in _____ in Central Africa.
- A male gorilla leader is called a _____.
- Gorillas share ____% of their DNA with humans.
- Mountain gorillas are _____ Endangered.
- Gorillas build a new sleeping _____ every night.
- Gorillas are important _____ dispersers in the forest.

Answers: rainforests | Silverback | 98.3 | Critically | nest | seed

Habitat Map & Ecosystem Analysis



Ecosystem Role: Gorillas are critical seed dispersers. As they move through the forest eating fruit, they deposit seeds far from the parent tree — enabling forest regeneration across wide areas. Without gorillas, certain tree species would fail to reproduce effectively, reducing biodiversity and weakening the carbon-storage capacity of the forest.

Threats Analysis

Threat	Impact Level	Primary Driver
Habitat loss & deforestation	CRITICAL	Agricultural expansion, logging
Poaching	HIGH	Bushmeat trade, illegal wildlife trade
Disease (including human respiratory illnesses)	HIGH	Human-wildlife contact, tourism proximity
Civil conflict in their range countries	MODERATE	Political instability in range countries

STEM Engineering Challenge: Model a Seed Dispersal Network ■

Research Question: How far can gorillas spread seeds across a forest?

Materials:

- Graph paper
- Pencil
- Ruler
- Dice or random number app

Method:

1. Draw a 10x10 grid representing 100 square km of forest. Mark 5 fruit trees.
2. Roll a die to determine how far your 'gorilla' moves each day (1-6 km).
3. Each time you land on or pass a fruit tree, mark a new 'seed drop' 1-3 km away in a random direction.
4. Simulate 30 days of gorilla movement. Count how many unique 'seed drops' you created.
5. Now remove the gorilla and count — how many areas of forest would get NO new seeds?

Conservation Organisations ■

Organisation	Website	Focus
Dian Fossey Gorilla Fund	fossey.org	Field research & anti-poaching
WWF Mountain Gorilla Programme	wwf.org	Habitat protection & policy
African Wildlife Foundation	awf.org	Community conservation
Gorilla Doctors	gorilladoctors.org	Veterinary care

Ecology explained: This models a real ecological concept called seed shadow. A single gorilla can deposit seeds across hundreds of square kilometres per year. Without them, forest regeneration becomes clustered around parent trees — reducing genetic diversity and forest resilience.

Writing Prompts & Research Tasks ■

Prompt 1: Write a 200-word argument: should tourists be allowed to visit wild gorillas? Consider the economic benefits to local communities versus the health risks to the gorillas.

Prompt 2: Research frame: Choose one of the four gorilla subspecies and write a profile comparing its conservation status, population trend, and the specific threats it faces compared to the others.

Prompt 3: Persuasive letter: Write to the government of DR Congo arguing for increased protected areas for gorillas. Use three pieces of evidence from this pack.

Critical Thinking Questions ■

1. Gorilla numbers increased slightly in recent years — what combination of actions made this happen?
2. How should researchers balance scientific access with animal health (gorillas catch human colds)?
3. Many gorillas live in countries affected by civil conflict. How does political instability make conservation harder?
4. If you were designing a conservation programme, what would your top three priorities be and why?

Zoo Explorers packs are free to print and share. New animal every month at [zooexplorers.com](https://www.zooexplorers.com)